

Do It Yourself (And Don'ts, Too)

Prakash Ballakoor

Forget registration forms. Open padlocks. And in nine seconds, get someone to stay at your site. Cryptic? Read on!

www.bugmenot.com

You know how frustrating it is when you come across sites that require you to register even to browse through them. And what about downloading stuff? Sure, many sites don't require you to register, but think of sites like Adobe.com. There you are, intending to download the Adobe CS3 trial from Adobe's Web site. Go ahead, register! Spend five boring minutes! And all for nothing in return, and we're not even talking about un-checking all the newsletter subscription boxes.

Worse are sites that show up on Google and you find you need to subscribe. Say you want to read through the Times Of India e-newspaper, and there's again a daunting registration process. Then there are some questionable sites where you just don't want to give away personal information. Or even make up stuff... because your imagination just isn't working as you're waiting to see the page! You're probably now just as frustrated with this rant...

Bugmenot.com offers respite. Just type in a Web site address in the text box at Bugmenot.com, and you'll see a list of usernames and passwords, along with the success rates for each of them. You can actually use these and login to the site you want to go to, and voila—no need to register!

Bugmenot has accounts for about 1,50,000 sites. You too can do your bit for bugmenot.com by registering using a non-personalised username and password and added it to the site for someone else to use. Bugmenot also provides instant, disposable e-mail addresses when one requires an instant address to receive at least one mail from a site (read registration responses). This keeps spammers at bay. E-mails gotten from Bugmenot stay for 24 hours. Just think of a name and address and send it to Bugmenot. For example, dontbugme@bugmenot.com.

To access this account, you just type in the address you gave, and click "Read e-mail" at <http://email.bugmenot.com>! Incredibly useful, no?



Bugmenot takes the headache out of online forms

www.webdesign.org

A Web presence is necessary for many businesses. It's like an identity. But identity is just not enough to get noticed; one's Web site needs to be designed well to stand out from millions, as you know very well. The attention span of a casual surfer is nine seconds (according to BBC News, the Science / Technology division), within which one decides if the site is worth spending time on. We've done a *Fast Track* to Web design in our July 2006 issue; this site gives you more resources.

Webdesign.org teaches you all the theoretical and practical aspects of an effective and attractive Web presence. This site covers Web Design basics such as design principles, colour theory, templates, and tuning, which are essential knowl-



Webdesign.org—handy advice for your site

edge for any Web designer. There's a tutorial section on Adobe Photoshop, and a section on vector graphics covers tutorials on CoreDraw and Adobe Illustrator.

Animation adds dynamism to a site. A section on Flash and Swish teach one how to get started on animation. The site also carries tutorials on 3D graphics, HTML and CSS, and Web programming—PHP, ASP, and JavaScript. The tutorials don't stop at this: site maintenance topics like Web promotion, domain registration, and hosting services are also taken care of. Then there are the little things like showcasing Web design, and a site of the day and month. Well worth a visit or two—or three or four or more!

www.instructables.com

DIY allows you to use your creative abilities (along with available tools, of course) to give vent to your creative desires. Step-by-step instructions makes any complex DIY a piece of cake... but you don't want it to be a piece of cake every time you take up a DIY. Ideally, one just needs a helping hand; comments and criticism can go a long way in making a DIY project more enjoyable.

That's what instructables.com is all about—it provides a platform where people can share what they're doing, how they're doing it, and learn from and collaborate with others. The site has some of the coolest projects—from a night-vision webcam to a rechargeable LED flashlight powered by magnets, how to open any padlock, and more. (We're sure that padlock bit has already gotten you interested.)



Find the craziest of projects at Instructables

Projects are aided by photos and videos, with less of an emphasis on text. Registering at the site allows you to upload your own DIY and collaborate with other projects if you can contribute. The layout, as is the case with every site we feature in this space, is easy to grasp. Comments on the pages allow one to visualise how others reacted to the project—whether it was good or a waste of time or whether there was a better method to achieve the same results.

Overall, one wonderful site for those who like to do things themselves—but please don't go about opening padlocks. Don't even think about it. ☒

prakash_ballakoor@thinkdigit.com